FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Back pain was once a problem associated with middle age and the later stages of life. Not anymore. Across today's India, it's becoming a creeping epidemic that is getting younger by the day. People in their twenties and thirties are showing up at spine clinics with conditions that doctors used to see only in patients decades older. The numbers are alarming. An estimated 15 per cent of the world's spine patients are in India, with 1.5 million cases, second only to China's. But what should truly make us sit up is the pace at which the pain graph is shifting downward into younger age brackets. A study across 18 Indian states found not only a sharp rise in back pain cases between 2020 and 2023, the highest prevalence was in the 18-38 age group. A 2024 analysis offered a more chilling data point: low back pain is now a leading cause of disability among Indians aged 10 and above. Worse, it peaks in the 25-49 age group, the very years meant to be the most productive. Thankfully, there's one mitigating factor. Medical innovation is reshaping spine care, with exciting new developments in minimally invasive surgery, robotics and regenerative therapies.

The source of the danger is not hard to identify. We are turning into a sedentary species. The usual suspects are obvious: desk jobs, long hours at the screens and a culture of poor posture. But the real villain is the mobile phone in our hand. Held below eye level, with the head permanently tilted at a dangerous 30 to 45-degree angle, this bad posture is the standard for everyone, including young kids. It makes the head four times heavier for the neck muscles to bear, from about 6 kg to 25 kg. The distortion radiates downwards. The lack of natural movement weakens the muscles and the very structure that holds us upright. Result: the spine is ageing faster than the body. The 2023 Global Burden of Disease study ranks low back pain among the top 10 causes of early death and poor health worldwide. What the medical data presents is nothing short of an unvarnished X-ray of a national crisis.

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The evidence is everywhere. A 2024 cross-sector analysis estimated that 76 per cent of working-age Indians suffer from work-related musculoskeletal disorders; 60 per cent have low back pain. The problem hits hardest among those glued to screens. A 2024 study of computer engineering students found nearly 60 per cent suffered from 'tech-neck syndrome'. Among corporate employees too, a 2025 study found half of those aged 22-40 reported neck pain. A 2023 survey of tech workers under 35 revealed 53.4 per cent had musculoskeletal disorders. Shockingly but not surprisingly, even schoolchildren are affected. A 2024 survey of grades 8-12 found 61 per cent of students using e-learning devices reporting neck pain. Added to that is the old bane of heavy school bags.

The picture becomes grimmer once you add modern lifestyle ingredients to the mix. Hours in front of screens trap the body in one position. Poor diet adds another layer. Vitamin D and magnesium deficiencies impair calcium absorption, which weakens bones and softens the vertebrae. Processed food going hand in hand with lack of exercise leads to obesity, resulting in the overloading of discs and joints, promoting muscle loss and inflammation. Stress compounds the problem, with chronic muscle tension distorting posture over time and cortisol eroding bone strength. This is the perfect recipe for a painful back.

Yet the story is not without hope. What was once a life sentence of pain is now, in most cases, manageable. Take the case of Rohan Mehta, a 29-year-old DJ in Delhi. He was one of those new-age victims of a slipped disc, brought on by long hours hunched over his console. But Rohan had options his parents' generation never had. Instead of being condemned to bed rest or bulky braces, he had surgeons accessing his spine through keyhole-sized incisions, stabilising his vertebrae with nano-sized tools, neuro-navigation systems and cameras beaming a live feed to CT and MRI scanners. Within weeks, after rehab, Rohan was back at his turntable. A step up from these minimally invasive bone graft techniques is robotic surgery, with Augmented Reality doing duty as a real-time X-ray visor. There are also new kinds of custom-fitted implants, like 3D-printed titanium cages and spacers. An even more futuristic scenario lies in the regenerative potential of stem cells and Platelet-Rich Plasma injections. Doctors advise caution on those for now, but it's like a window opening up to a future for those seeking alternatives to surgery. India also has to perfect the restorative potential of yoga and ayurveda, applied mindfully, in conjunction with proper diagnostics.

In this week's cover story, Senior Editor Sonali Acharjee takes you through the scale of India's spinal crisis and the frontiers of treatment. But the best cure is, as always, prevention. Ergonomic chairs and ortho-friendly mattresses and pillows help. But the most crucial accessory is awareness, among parents, schools and workplaces. The real key lies in movement. Stand up, stretch, walk, bend, run. The key is to create a lifestyle where you stay on your feet. Do not let your back give way before your spirit.

(Aroon Purie)